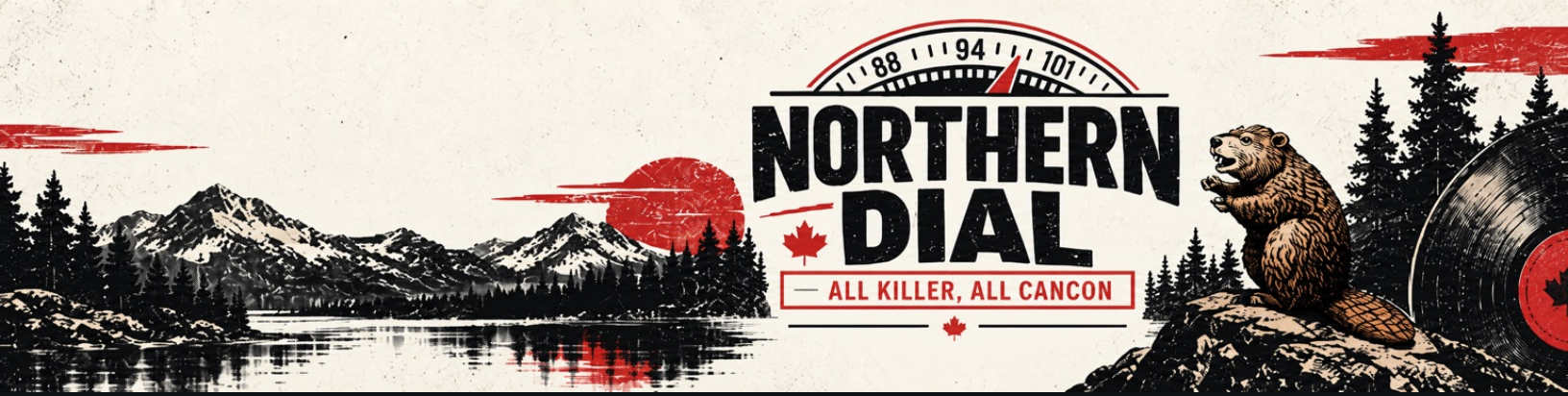




BRAND, MESSAGING & STYLE GUIDE

How Northern Dial looks, sounds and shows up.

ALL KILLER, ALL CANCON

A working guide for Northern Dial's brand foundations, messaging hierarchy, editorial voice and visual system. Use it to keep the website, artist pages, social graphics, outreach and future product work moving in one clear direction.

BRAND CORE

The shortest version of what Northern Dial is and why it exists.

“ Northern Dial is a Canadian music discovery platform built to make finding great music feel exciting again.

OUR MANDATE

Surface excellent Canadian music across genres, eras, regions and levels of fame. Give listeners context, not clutter. Make independent artists feel at home beside household names. Build a living map of Canadian music that people can actually listen to.

THE PROMISE

Press play and hear something worth knowing. Click deeper and understand who made it, where they fit and what to try next.

WHO IT IS FOR

- Curious listeners who want discovery without algorithmic sameness.
- Canadian music fans who want more than the usual national canon.
- Artists and scenes that deserve context, visibility and a durable home.
- Industry, media and cultural partners looking for an accessible window into Canadian music.

ONE-LINE POSITIONING

A human-curated Canadian music radio station, discovery engine and editorial archive, all connected by one constantly growing artist library.



MESSAGING ARCHITECTURE

The core ideas Northern Dial should return to again and again.

1 Discovery First

The job is not to show off expertise. It is to help somebody find a song, artist or story they did not know they needed.

2 Canada, Expanded

Canadian music is not one sound, one city or one era. Northern Dial should constantly widen the picture.

3 Human Curation

Algorithms can sort. Northern Dial connects dots through taste, context, sequencing and editorial judgment.

4 Context Matters

Every artist page, feature and listening path should make the next click more meaningful than the last.

5 Big + Small Together

Drake can sit beside a self-released act from Winnipeg. Fame changes reach, not eligibility.

6 Built to Listen

Editorial is never detached from the music. Wherever possible, readers should be one tap away from hearing the thing itself.



VOICE & TONE

Smart, warm, specific and allergic to corporate mush.

WE SOUND LIKE

- A music obsessive who knows when to stop talking.
- A sharp editor with taste, curiosity and receipts.
- A Canadian publication that does not need to wave a flag every sentence.
- A friend handing you the aux cord and saying, “Trust me.”
- Someone who can be funny without turning every line into a bit.

WE DO NOT SOUND LIKE

- A tourism board.
- A grant application in public-facing copy.
- An AI-generated music encyclopedia.
- A hype machine that calls everything iconic, groundbreaking or essential.
- A gatekeeper lecturing people about what they should like.

tone controls

Editorial

- Confident, contextual and economical.

Artist-facing

- Respectful, clear and genuinely curious.

Social

- Fast, playful and conversational.

Grant / partner

- Credible, measurable and culturally literate.

Product / UI

- Direct, useful and low-friction.

HOUSE RULE

Be specific enough that the sentence could only belong to Northern Dial. If a line could appear on any music startup, rewrite it.



EDITORIAL RULES

Small choices that keep hundreds of pages sounding like one publication.

01 Lead with the answer.

Open with what matters, then add context.

02 Prefer concrete language.

Name the city, record, scene, collaborator, year or sound when it helps.

03 No synthetic hype.

Avoid empty superlatives. Earn excitement with detail.

04 No em dashes.

Use commas, parentheses, colons or a clean new sentence instead.

05 Respect names and identity.

Use artist-preferred names, pronouns, capitalization and regional labels.

06 Link the ecosystem.

Artist pages should connect to features, releases, listening paths and relevant videos.

CORE MESSAGING

Homepage promise

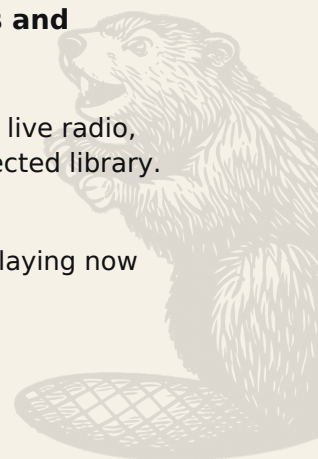
Discover Canadian music worth turning up. Listen live, meet the artists and follow the connections across scenes, cities and generations.

Short description

Northern Dial is a Canadian music discovery platform combining live radio, artist profiles, editorial features and listening paths in one connected library.

Preferred CTAs

Listen live • Meet the artist • Explore the library • Hear what is playing now



VISUAL SYSTEM

Vintage Canadian print culture, tightened for a modern digital product.

CORE PALETTE

PAPER

#F6F1E7

INK

#111214

SIGNAL RED

#C7443E

MUTED INK

#66635F

VISUAL INGREDIENTS

- Off-white paper rather than bright digital white.
- Black woodcut or screen-print forms with visible grain and imperfect edges.
- Signal red used as punctuation, not wallpaper.
- Canadian landscape cues: water, tree lines, mountain silhouettes and weather.
- Music cues: vinyl, radio dials, meters, frequency marks and physical media.
- The beaver acts as a mascot, not generic national clip art.

TYPOGRAPHY DIRECTION

Headlines should feel bold, condensed and poster-like. Body copy should stay neutral and highly readable. Utility labels can use bold all-caps with a little breathing room. The logo lettering is a brand mark, not a substitute for body typography.

CANADIAN MUSIC, TURNED UP.

UTILITY LABEL / ALL CAPS / SHORT

Let the hierarchy do the shouting. Body copy should feel calm beside the louder display language.



LOGO & IMAGE USAGE

Use the lockup like a flagship brand asset, not a sticker.



DO

- Give the lockup room to breathe.
- Use it on cream, white or dark fields with strong contrast.
- Keep the dial, wordmark, tagline and beaver proportions intact.
- Use the full lockup when brand recognition matters most.

DO NOT

- Stretch, rotate or rebuild the wordmark.
- Swap the red for an unrelated accent colour.
- Place it on busy photography without a quiet field.
- Turn the beaver into unrelated clip art.

IMAGERY RULE

Photography, release art and editorial graphics should feel collected, tactile and rooted in music culture. Avoid generic concert stock, sterile startup gradients and any treatment that erases an artist's real visual identity.



DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

The brand should help people listen, not get between them and the music.

1 Persistent audio

The stream keeps playing while people browse artist information, features and listening paths.

2 Now playing is a doorway

Artist name, song and artwork should connect directly to the artist record whenever available.

3 Overlays beat dead ends

Artist info should open above the radio experience so curiosity does not interrupt listening.

4 Editorial links both ways

Features should link to artist pages, and artist pages should surface relevant features.

CONTENT FORMATS

- Artist profile: who they are, where they are from, what they sound like and what to hear next.
- New release: lead with the record, add two or three useful context points, then make listening easy.
- Feature / essay: a clear angle, no throat-clearing and embedded media where it strengthens the story.
- Social post: one idea per asset, concise hook, useful caption and a clear path back to listening or reading.



THE NORTHERN DIAL TEST

Before anything ships, ask these questions.

- 01** Does this help somebody discover or understand Canadian music?
- 02** Is the copy specific enough to sound human and editorial?
- 03** Are we giving the artist context without flattening them into genre tags?
- 04** Can the user hear the music quickly?
- 05** Does the visual feel tactile and unmistakably Northern Dial?
- 06** Is red acting as signal rather than decoration?
- 07** Have we avoided generic hype, corporate language and forced Canadiana?
- 08** Does this connect back into the larger library instead of becoming an isolated dead end?

BOILERPLATE

Northern Dial is an independent Canadian music discovery project that combines live radio, editorial publishing and a structured artist library to help people hear more, know more and follow the connections across Canadian music.

